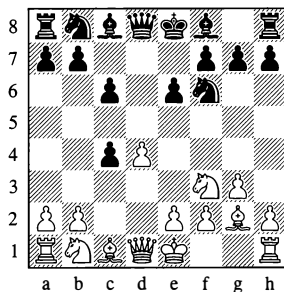


Chapter 3

Catalan 4...dxc4



5...c6

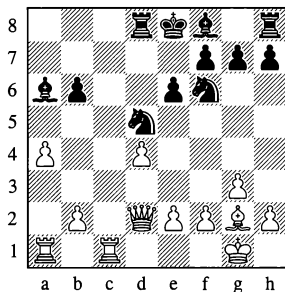
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 c6

6.♘e5

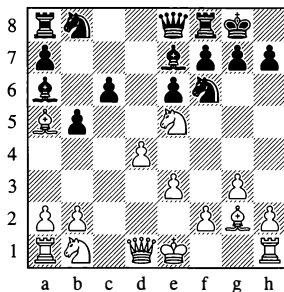
A) 6...b5 7.♘xc6 ♖b6 8.♘a5!	35
A1) 8...♙xa5†	36
A2) 8...♘d5 9.♙d2	38
A21) 9...a6	39
A22) 9...♘c6 10.♘xc6 ♖xc6 11.e4	41
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B21) 13...♘d7	48
B22) 13...h6!?	49

A2) note to 9.♙d2



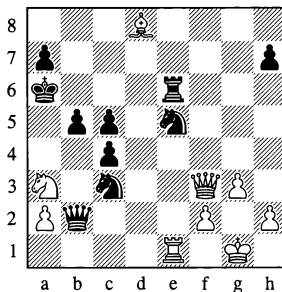
17.a5!N

B1 1) note to 9...c5



12.a3!N

B21) note to 21...♙a6!



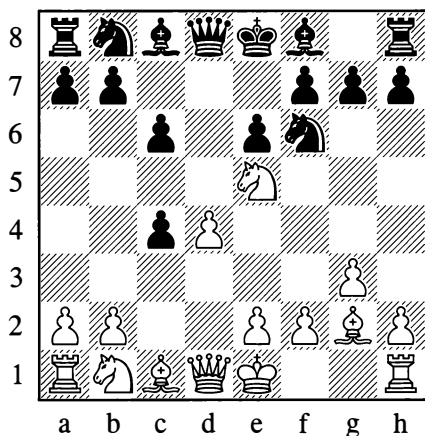
26.♖a8!!

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♗g2 c6

I wouldn't say that Black has tried hard to rehabilitate this line, but there have been some attempted improvements recently.

6.♗e5

In my opinion this is the most principled continuation. White is aiming to regain the pawn, and maintain typical Catalan pressure.



In this position we have to look at two major alternatives for Black: A) 6...b5 and B) 6...♗b4†. I would also like to mention two minor options, which deserve a little attention, though not more.

6...♘bd7 7.♘xc4 ♘b6 (Black's idea is to get some play on the queenside after 8.♘xb6 axb6, but certainly White has a different plan) 8.♗e5! c5 9.♗e3 ♘bd5 (9...cxd4 10.♗xd4 ♗b4† 11.♘c3 ♘bd5 12.0-0 0-0 13.♖b3± was also clearly better for White in Favarel – Resnjanskij, Naujac 2012.) This is what happened in D'Costa – Richmond, Birmingham 2000. White should have continued 10.dxc5 ♖a5† 11.♗d2 ♖xc5 12.♗a3! with a nice position.

6...♗e7 7.0-0 0-0 8.♘c3 ♘bd7 9.♘xc4 ♘b6 10.♗e5 Once again it is the same idea: White

avoids the knight swap and maintains a clear positional edge, thanks to his space advantage and strong Catalan bishop. There are a large number of games which have reached this position, but the evaluation is obviously in White's favour so I will just show one continuation: 10...♘fd7 11.♘f3 ♘d5 12.♗d2 (I also like 12.♖c2 b6 13.♗d1 ♗b7 14.e4 ♘xc3 15.bxc3±) 12...b6 13.e4 ♘xc3 14.♗xc3 ♗b7 15.♖e2 a5 16.♗fd1± White had a nice version of a Queen's Indian in Gleizerov – Racioppo, Turin 2000.

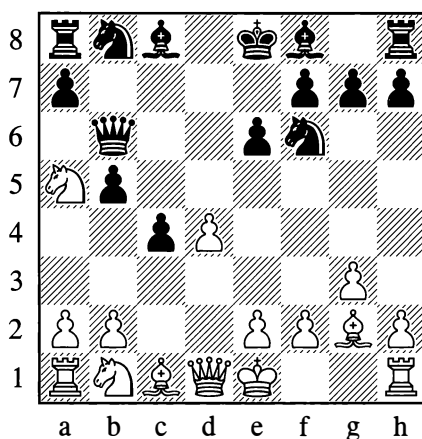
A) 6...b5

In this position White has a promising idea at his disposal. If White manages to regain the pawn he would get a very pleasant position with typical Catalan pressure.

7.♘xc6

7.a4 transposes to a line after 5...b5 that I prefer to avoid; see 7.♗e5 in the notes on page 127.

7...♖b6 8.♗a5!



This move was first played by Viktor Korchnoi in 2004. Even after more than 60 years of playing the Catalan, the closest we have to a superhero in chess still has something

new and surprising to add to opening theory. Actually the knight jump to the edge of the board looks extremely strange, as we should not forget that Black can capture it with check! Nevertheless, White has serious threats along the h1-a8 diagonal, and all the tactics look great for him.

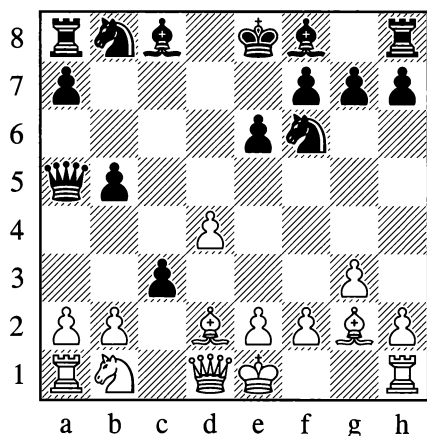
We now have two serious options: **A1) 8...♖xa5†N** or **A2) 8...♘d5**.

Just bad is 8...♗b4†? 9.♗d2 ♗xd2† (9...♗xa5 10.♗xa8 ♘c6 11.0-0 ♗xd2 12.♗xc6† ♖xc6 13.♖xd2± and Black has no compensation for the exchange) 10.♖xd2 ♘d5 11.♘c3! and Black cannot avoid losing material. For example, 11...♗b7 12.♘xb7 ♖xb7 13.♘xd5 exd5 14.♖e3† ♕f8 15.♖g5+.

A1) 8...♖xa5†N

Capturing the knight leads to a forced line, which has never been tested in practice, so you will have to be content with my elaborations on Korchnoi's analysis.

9.♗d2 c3



10.bxc3

Less convincing is 10.♘c3 b4 11.♗xa8 bxc3 12.♗xc3 ♖b6.

10...♘d5 11.c4 b4 12.cxd5 exd5

Pinning the d-pawn is possible, but White also has a promising position in this case:

12...♗b7 13.0-0 ♗xd5

13...exd5 allows a tactical solution: 14.♖b3 ♗e7 (Black loses the pawn after 14...♘d7 15.a3) 15.♘c3! ♘c6 16.♘xd5 ♘xd4 17.♖c4 With a winning advantage.

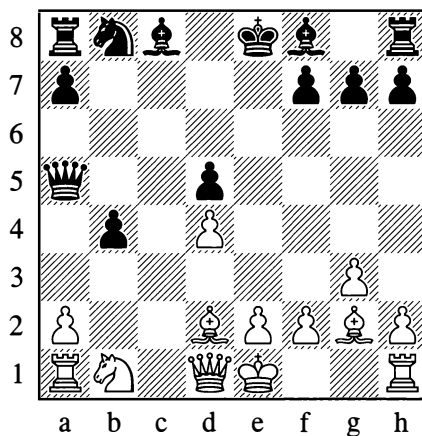
14.e4 ♗b7 15.a3! ♗e7

Or 15...♖b5 16.axb4 ♗xb4 17.♘a3! with a clear advantage.

16.d5!

Black faces serious problems: most probably he will lose the b4-pawn, as White is threatening simply ♖b3 and then just capturing the pawn.

Let's return to the main line. White should be better in the long term thanks to his superior pawn structure, but the computer claims that White can also strike immediately with the unexpected:



13.♘a3!

This subtle manoeuvre was suggested to me by my computer. White is only slightly better after more 'human' play:

13.♗f4 ♗e6 14.♘d2 ♗e7 15.0-0 0-0 16.♘b3 ♖b5 17.♘c5! ♘d7

Black cannot take the pawn with 17...♗xc5 18.dxc5 ♖xc5, as after 19.e4± White regains the pawn with a clear advantage.

18.♘xe6 fxe6 19.♙h3

The pair of bishops gives White a pleasant edge.

13...♘c6

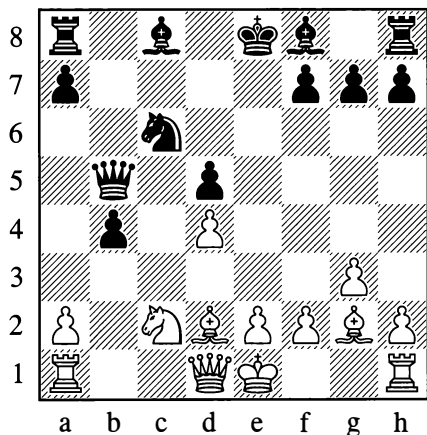
Certainly bad is 13...♞xa3 14.♙xd5 and White wins.

If 13...♙e7 14.♘c2 ♞b5 15.a3! ♘c6 16.♘xb4 ♘xb4 17.axb4 ♙xb4 18.♞a4! White gets exactly the kind of desirable position he was aiming for.

14.♘c2 ♞b5

Otherwise Black gets into deep trouble:

14...♙e6 15.0–0 ♙e7 (15...♞b5 is met strongly by 16.e4! with the idea 16...♙e7 17.a4! ♞a5 [17...bxa3 loses to 18.exd5 ♙xd5 19.♙b1+–] 18.♘e3 and Black cannot avoid losing material.) 16.a3 ♞b5 17.♙xb4 ♘xb4 18.♘xb4 ♙xb4 19.axb4 ♞xb4 20.♞a4† Black is going to lose the a7-pawn.



15.a4!

A very effective move which forces Black to accept an inferior pawn structure.

15.0–0 ♙f5! would allow Black to escape to an unclear position.

15...bxa3

After 15...♞a5 the central push 16.e4 would come with great effect. 16...♙d6 (16...♙e6 17.0–0 ♙e7 18.♘e3! is already lost for Black) 17.0–0 ♙a6 18.♙e1 0–0 19.exd5 ♘e7 20.♘xb4! A nice touch that secures White's advantage. 20...♙xb4 21.d6 ♙xd2 22.dxe7 ♙xe1 23.exf8=♞† ♙xf8 24.♞xe1 White has a healthy extra pawn.

16.0–0!

With idea of waiting for the f8-bishop to move and only then capturing on a3, winning a tempo compared with the immediate capture on a3.

Clearly worse is 16.♘xa3 ♙xa3 17.♙xa3 0–0 and White has some difficulties defending the d4-pawn.

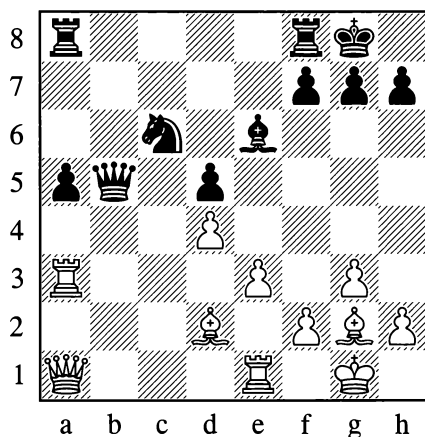
16...♙e6

If 16...♙e7 then we play 17.♘xa3 ♙xa3 18.♙xa3 and Black cannot take with 18...♘xd4? in view of 19.♙a5 followed by 20.♙xd5 with decisive threats.

17.♙e1 ♙e7 18.♘xa3 ♙xa3 19.♙xa3 0–0

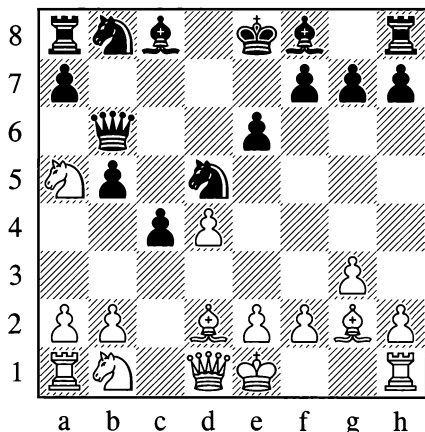
Black still cannot take the central pawn: 19...♘xd4 20.e4! White's initiative is decisive.

20.♞a1 a5 21.e3



The bishop pair and Black's weak pawns on a5 and d5 give White a clear positional advantage.

A2) 8...♟d5 9.♟d2



Black has a wide choice of moves here, with the main two being A21) 9...a6 and A22) 9...♟c6. However, I was unable to find a route to equality for Black in any of the lines analysed.

9...♝xd4?!

This capture is very risky for Black.

10.♟c3 a6

Other options are much worse:

10...♝c5 11.0-0 and Black is helpless against White's simple threat of ♟xd5 followed by ♟e3 and the d5-pawn will fall.

10...♟d7 11.♟xb5 ♝c5 12.a4 a6 13.b4! and White wins material.

11.0-0 ♟d7 12.a4 ♟7b6

12...b4 runs into 13.♟xd5 exd5 14.♟c6 and Black's position collapses.

13.♝c2

Black is in serious trouble due to his poor development.

9...b4 10.♟xc4 ♝xd4 11.♝c2

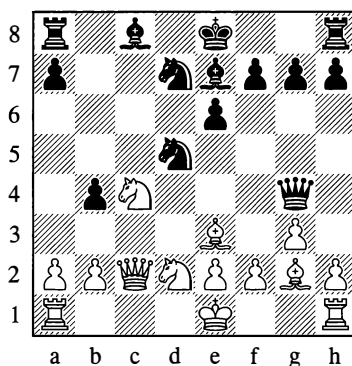
It is difficult for Black to deal with White's initiative.

11...♟d7

Black cannot play 11...♟a6 12.♝a4† ♟d8 13.♟e3! as White has a clear advantage.

12.♟e3 ♝g4 13.♟bd2 ♟e7

13...♟b7 is met strongly by 14.♟e4! with the unpleasant idea of ♟ed6†. After 14...♟xe3 15.♟xe3 ♝g6 16.♟d1 Black faces serious problems with development.



14.♟xa7!

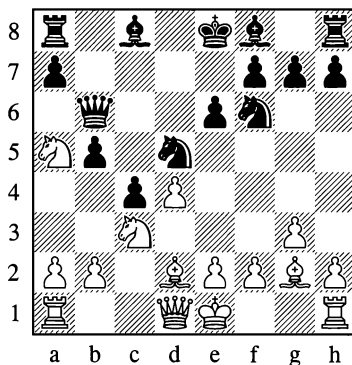
White wins the pawn, as Black cannot take the bishop.

Amazingly enough my engine likes the mysterious 14.h4!?, creating problems for the black queen.

14...♟xa7 15.♟d6†! ♟xd6 16.♝xc8† ♟e7 17.♝xh8

This wins for White.

9...♟d7 10.♟c3 ♟7f6



11.a4!

Using the fact that Black cannot play 11...a6 12.axb5 axb5 13.♖xd5 ♖xd5 14.♗xd5 exd5 15.♖xc4! ♖xa1 16.♖xb6 ♖xd1† 17.♕xd1, when he remains a pawn down

11...b4 12.♖xc4 bxc3

12...♗xd4 is apparently the best chance for Black, though White retains a nice positional advantage after 13.♖xd5 ♖xd5 14.♖c1±.

13.♖xb6 cxd2† 14.♗xd2 axb6 15.0–0

The position is clearly in White's favour as he is able to seize the initiative, while Black will have to develop his pieces:

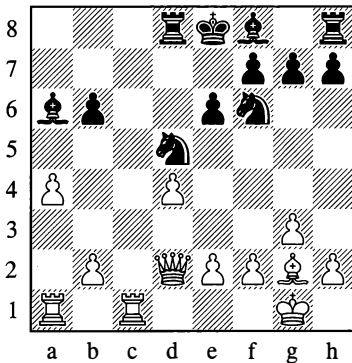
15...♗a6

15...♗b4 16.♗c2 0–0 17.e4 ♖e7 18.♗b3 ♗a5 19.♖f1 White has an overwhelming advantage, with one of the threats being 20.♗a3 with the idea of b2-b4.

16.♖f1 ♖d8

The lesser evil would have been 16...♗b4 17.♗d1 ♗a5! (17...0–0 loses immediately after 18.e4 ♖e7 19.♗b3 ♗a5 20.♗a3! followed by b2-b4, trapping the bishop on a5.) 18.e4 ♖b4 19.♗f1 ♗xf1 20.♗xf1 0–0 21.f3 ♖f8 22.♖c4± Black is doomed to a passive defence.

We have been following Slugin – Kharlov, St Petersburg 2007, and here the winning idea would be:

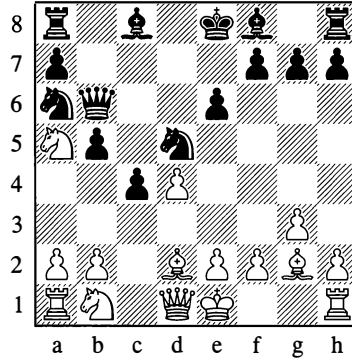


17.a5!N b5

One of the ideas comes to light after 17...♗b4 18.♗c2 ♗xa5 19.♖xa5! bxa5 20.♗c6† and White is winning.

18.e4 ♗b4 19.♗d3 ♖e7 20.♖c7 0–0 21.♖a7+– Black is losing the b5-pawn.

9...♖a6



10.♖c3N

A natural improvement over 10.a4 b4 11.♖xc4 ♗xd4, when Black was fine in Colls Gelaberto – Perez Candelario, La Massana 2008.

10...♖ab4 11.♖xd5 ♖xd5

11...exd5 12.a3 and White wins material.

12.a4 ♗d7

12...b4 13.♖xc4 ♗xd4 14.♖c1 transposes to a position from the 9...♖d7 line above.

13.axb5 ♗xb5 14.0–0!

White doesn't have much after 14.♗c3 ♗e7 15.0–0 0–0.

14...♗e7

In the event of 14...♗xd4 15.♗c1 ♗e7 16.e4 ♖f6 17.♗c3 ♗d7 18.♖xc4 0–0 19.♖d1 ♗c6 20.e5 ♖d5 21.♖d6 White develops an initiative.

15.♗e1!

Covering the b4-square.

15...0–0 16.e4 ♖f6 17.♗c3

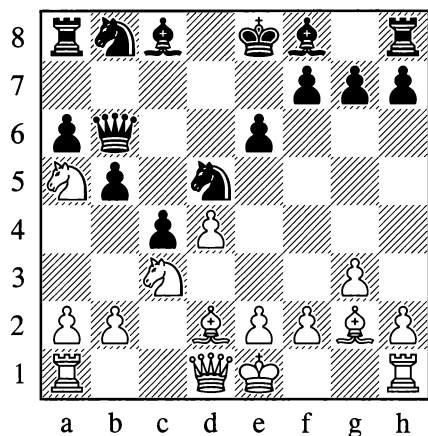
White preserves a pleasant positional edge.

A21) 9...a6

I have promoted this move from a sideline in *GM 1* to a main line. The idea is quite logical, preparing to remove the rook from the dangerous diagonal.

10. ♖c3

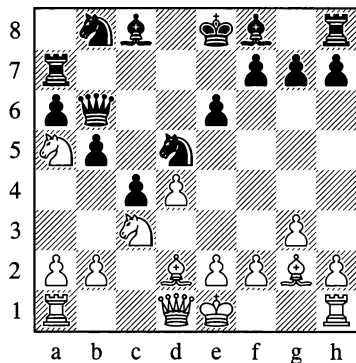
There is only one game in the database here, with Black choosing to capture on c3:



10... ♖xc3

10... ♖a7

I considered this in *GM 1*, and the outlook is still poor for Black.



11. ♕xd5

11. ♖xd5 exd5 12. ♕xd5 allows Black the following tactical resource: 12...c3! 13. ♕xc3 b4 14. ♖c4 ♖d8 with unnecessary complications.

11... ♖xa5

After 11...exd5 12. ♖xd5 ♖e6 13. ♖f4! ♖e4 14. 0-0 ♖xd4 15. ♖c2± White's advantage in development starts to tell.

12. ♕g2 ♖d7

12... ♖b7 13. e4 ♕e7 14. ♖g4 allows White an obvious initiative.

13. d5 b4

Black cannot play 13... ♖b7 14. dxe6 ♖xd2 15. ♖xd2 ♕xg2, as after 16. exf7† ♖xf7 17. ♖g1 followed by ♖d2-f4xb8, White wins material.

14. dxe6

14. ♖a4 ♖b6 15. ♕e3 ♕c5 16. ♕xc5 ♖xc5 17. ♖e4 ♖b5 Black has a reasonable position.

14... fxe6

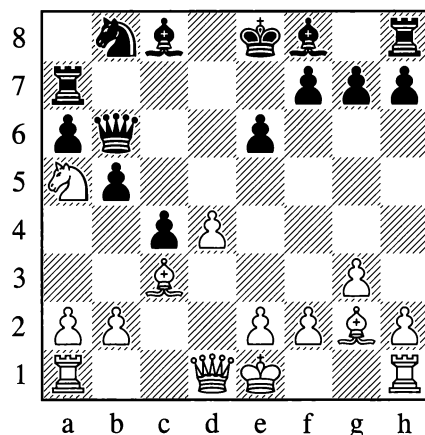
14... ♖xd2 15. ♖xd2 bxc3 16. exf7† ♖xf7 17. bxc3 ♕e7 18. ♕d5† White has an obvious advantage, because of Black's exposed king.

15. ♖e4 ♕b7 16. ♖c2

White is better positionally, due to Black's vulnerable pawn structure.

11. ♕xc3 ♖a7

Now I would like to propose a different approach:



12. 0-0

12. a4 ♕e7 13. b3 0-0 14. axb5 axb5 15. bxc4 b4 16. c5 ♖b5 17. ♖b3 ♖b7 was rather messy in Schneider – Feygin, Germany 2011.

12... ♖c7

12... ♕e7 13. d5 0-0 14. ♖c6 ♖xc6 15. dxc6± is clearly better for White.

13. a3

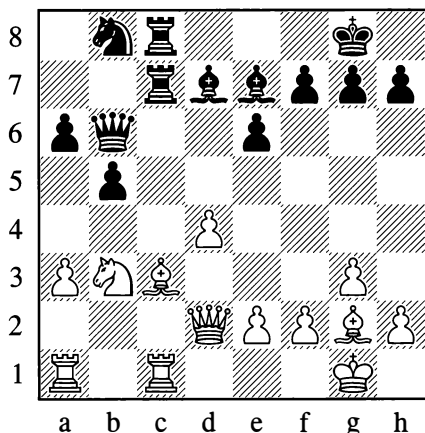
White has to prevent 13...b4.

13...♙e7 14.♚d2 0-0 15.♞fc1

White's plan is to follow up with 16.b3, exchanging Black's c4-pawn. The following is a good illustrative line:

15...♙d7 16.b3 cxb3 17.♜xb3 ♞fc8

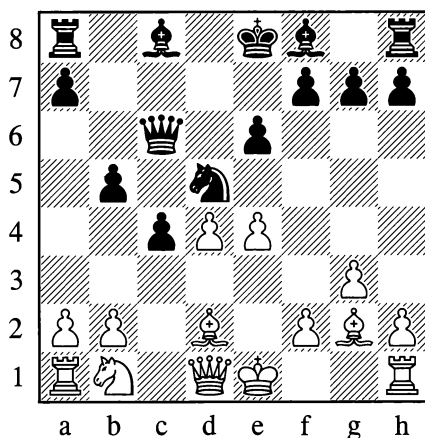
17...♙xa3? doesn't work in view of: 18.♞xa3 ♞xc3 19.♚xc3 b4 20.♚c5 ♚xc5 21.dxc5 bxa3 22.c6+–



18.♙a5 ♞xc1† 19.♞xc1 ♞xc1† 20.♚xc1 ♚a7 21.♙b4

With a clear positional advantage for White. His Catalan bishop is proving to be extremely effective.

A22) 9...♜c6 10.♜xc6 ♚xc6 11.e4



Black has tried two knight moves here: A221) 11...♜b4 and A222) 11...♜f6.

A221) 11...♜b4

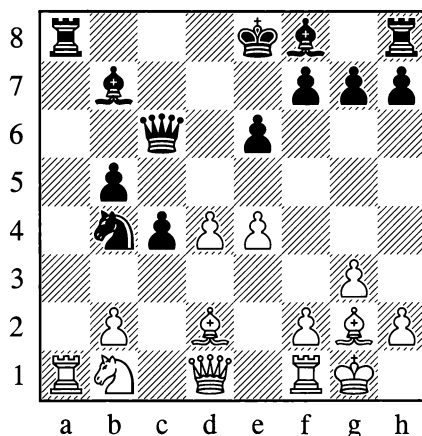
Landing the knight on d3 is a tempting idea, but the problem is that Black is unable to achieve his plan as White quickly seizes the initiative in the centre.

12.0-0 ♙b7 13.a4 a6N

This must be the critical continuation.

13...♜d3?! was played in Korchnoi – Moskalkenko, Barcelona 2004. Now White should have played the simple 14.axb5N ♚xb5 15.♙a5! ♚b3 (the b2-pawn is untouchable: 15...♚xb2? 16.♚a4† and White wins) 16.♙c3 with a clear advantage, as suggested by Moskalkenko.

14.axb5 axb5



15.d5 ♚b6 16.♞xa8† ♙xa8 17.dxe6 ♚xe6

After 17...fxe6 18.♙e3 ♚c6 19.♜c3 White is much better and is threatening ♚d1-h5xb5.

18.♜c3 ♙c5

Another line is 18...♚d7 19.♚h5 ♙e7 (Or 19...♜d3 20.♙a1 ♙c6 21.♙h3! ♚b7 22.♙e3 and I do not see how Black can prevent ♙a7.)

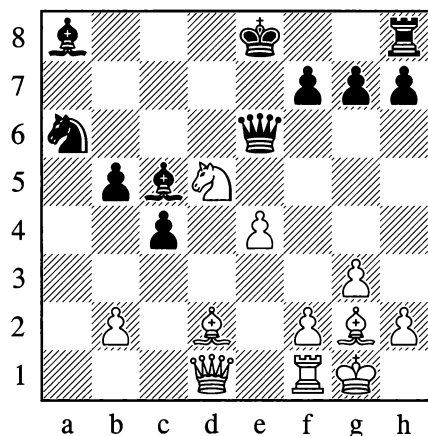
20. ♖xb5 ♖xb5 21. ♜xb5 ♜d3 22. ♙c3 and White has an extra pawn.

19. ♜d5!?

19. ♜xb5 0-0 20. ♙xb4 ♙xb4 21. ♖a4 also looks strong enough, but maybe Black has some chances for survival, thanks to his bishop pair.

19... ♜a6

19... ♜xd5 20. exd5 ♖d7 21. ♖e1† ♜f8 22. ♙c3 looks horrible for Black.



20.b4!

A welcome tactical resource, as Black was close to solving his opening problems.

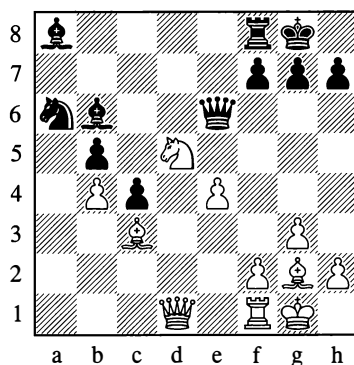
20...cxb3

Other options are:

20... ♙d4 21. ♙f4 ♙e5 22. ♖h5 ♙xf4 23. ♜xf4 ♖b6 24. ♖e5† with a winning position for White.

20... ♙a7 21. ♙c3 0-0 22. ♜f4! ♖b6 23. ♖g4 g6 24. ♜h5 with a decisive attack.

20... ♙b6 21. ♙c3 0-0 and now White has a beautiful manoeuvre:



22. ♙h3 ♖xh3 (22... ♖xe4 23. ♙g2 ♖e6 24. ♖e1 leaves the black queen with no squares, for example 24... ♖h6 25. ♜e7† ♜h8 26. ♜f5 and White wins.) 23. ♜e7† ♜h8 24. ♖d6 White has a winning attack, with threats such as 25. ♜g6†, or 25. ♙xg7† followed by ♜f5† and ♖f6.

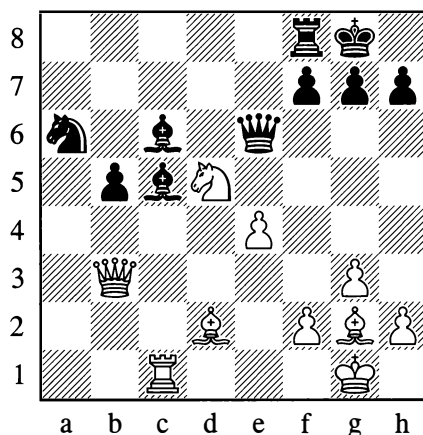
21. ♖xb3 ♙c6

21...0-0 22. ♖xb5± leaves White with a healthy extra pawn.

22. ♖c1

22. ♖a1 0-0 23. ♖xa6?! ♙xd5 24. ♖xd5 ♙xf2† 25. ♜xf2 ♖xa6 should be drawish.

22...0-0



23. ♙e3!

The point behind White's play.

23...♙xd5

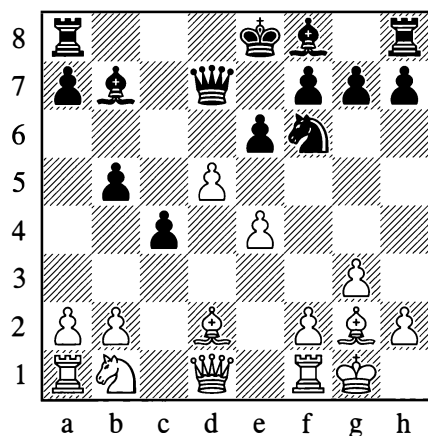
23...♙d6 24.♙xc5 ♘xc5 25.♙b4 ♙xd5
26.exd5 and White wins a pawn.

24.exd5 ♙b6 25.♙xc5 ♘xc5 26.♙e3 ♘a4

26...♘d7 27.♙e7! is even worse, as the
d-pawn should decide the issue.

27.♙e7

The dangerous passed pawn promises White
a clear advantage.

A222) 11...♘f6 12.0-0 ♙b7 13.d5! ♙d7N

The most solid response, though Black has
also tried a more ambitious approach:

13...♙a6 14.♙c3 exd5

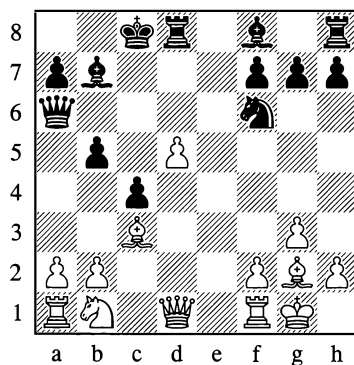
Other possibilities do not promise Black
adequate play either:

a) 14...♙e7 is actually not so bad, as after
15.d6! ♙xd6 16.e5 ♙xg2 17.♙xg2 Black
has 17...b4! enabling him to save the piece.
However, White still has the better game
after 18.exf6 bxc3 19.fxg7 ♙g8 20.♘xc3
♙xg7 21.♙e2±.

b) 14...b4 15.♙xf6 gxf6 16.♙e1 ♙c5 17.♘d2
0-0 (17...c3 18.bxc3 bxc3 19.♘b3±)
18.♙c1± and White is obviously better.

15.exd5 0-0-0

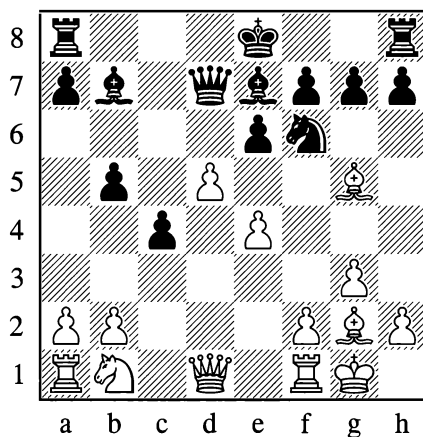
We have been following Trilobit –
Daverundle, Internet 2010. I found a simple
improvement for White:

**16.♙xf6N ♙xf6 17.♘c3 a6 18.♙c1!**

To be followed by 19.a4, and Black's
queenside pawn structure starts to collapse.

14.♙g5 ♙e7

After 14...exd5 15.♙xf6 (15.exd5 ♙e7
16.♘c3 0-0 17.d6 ♙d8 18.♙xb7 ♙xb7 is
quite defendable for Black) 15...gxf6 16.exd5
0-0-0 I now prefer: 17.♙h5 ♙b8 18.a4 b4
19.♘d2 With a clear positional advantage.

**15.♙xf6!**

A clever tactical trick that gives White a
promising position.

15...gxf6

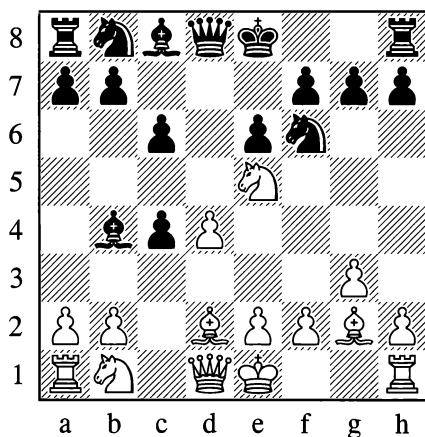
The problem for Black is that he cannot
recapture with the bishop: 15...♙xf6 16.e5!
♙e7 (16...♙xe5 17.♙h5! ♙c7 18.d6! ♙xd6
19.♙xb5†+- wins a piece) 17.dxe6 ♙xd1

18.♙xd1 ♖xg2 19.♗xg2! (An improvement on *GM 1*, as 19.exf7† ♗xf7 20.♗xg2 ♖hd8 21.♜c3 b4 gives Black some counterplay.) 19...fxe6 20.a4! b4 21.♜d2 c3 22.bxc3 bxc3 23.♜e4 Black is unable to hold the c-pawn, thanks to the following line: 23...♖c8 24.♖dc1 ♖b4 25.♖ab1 a5 26.♜xc3! ♖xc3 27.♖b3 White should convert his extra pawn.

16.♜c3

White is clearly better positionally.

B) 6...♖b4† 7.♖d2!



White sacrifices a second pawn, but in return he gets a dangerous initiative for his material deficit.

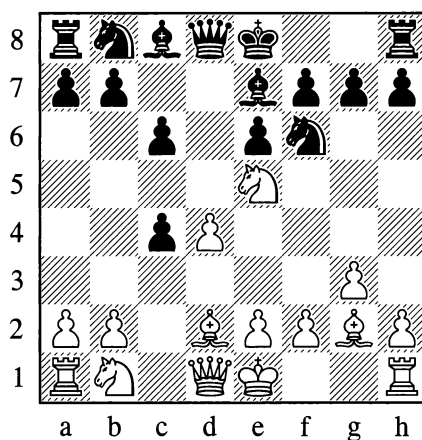
Another line runs 7.♜c3 ♜d5 with double-edged play.

We have reached another branching point. The main lines are **B1) 7...♖e7** and **B2) 7...♖xd4**.

7...♜a6 cannot be a serious move, after which I recommended 8.♖xb4 ♜xb4 9.0-0 in *GM 1*. Like many ideas it has now been employed in practice: 9...0-0 was R. Popov – Dibrov, Berdsk 2008, and now the simple 10.♜a3N followed by 11.♜axc4 would have secured a clear Catalan edge.

Dubious is 7...♖xd2† 8.♖xd2 ♜bd7 (8...b5?! doesn't work due to 9.♜xc6 ♖b6 10.♜a5! ♜d5 11.♜c3 and Black loses at least a pawn) 9.♜xc4 and, as usual, White has regained the pawn with a clear advantage. 9...0-0 10.0-0 ♖e7 11.♜c3 e5 was played in Gawlikowski – Weiner, Prague 1955, and now 12.♖fd1N ♖e8 13.e4± would have secured White's advantage.

B1) 7...♖e7



8.e3

This is White's best way to defend the d4-pawn.

After 8.♖e3 White's bishop appears to be rather vulnerable, and Black gets normal play after: 8...a5 (The exchange sacrifice 8...b5!? 9.♜xc6 ♜xc6 10.♖xc6† ♖d7 11.♖xa8 ♖xa8 12.0-0 0-0 might be an interesting alternative as well, and was tried in Zenzero – Kreisl, Moscow 2012.) 9.a4 (9.♜xc4 allows the queenside advance 9...b5 10.♜e5 b4 11.♖d2 0-0 and Black is fine) In Stefanova – Kurajica, Benasque 1997, the simple 9...♜d5 gave Black comfortable play after 10.♜xc4 b5 11.axb5 cxb5.

Black immediately has another decision to make. He can try **B1 1) 8...0-0** or **B12) 8...b5**.

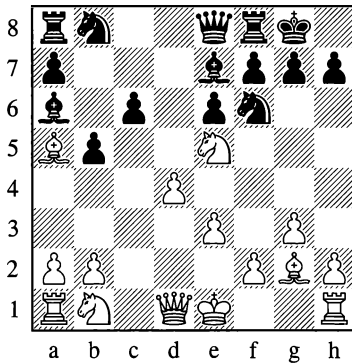
B11) 8...0-0 9.♟xc4

9.♟a3 ♟xa3 10.bxa3 b5 is double-edged – especially the following important line: 11.♟b4 (11.♟xc6 doesn't work: 11...♟xc6 12.♟xc6 ♟b8 13.♟b4 ♟c7! and Black is simply better. 11.a4 ♟d5 is unclear.) 11...♟e8 12.♟xc6 ♟xc6 13.♟xc6 ♟d7 14.♟xa8 ♟xa8 Black has interesting compensation.

9...c5

Black's natural attempt to undermine White's centre.

Other options are not so attractive. 9...b5?! 10.♟a5! ♟e8 11.♟e5 ♟a6 was Romero Holmes – Murillo, San Jose 2013, and now White should have continued with the following accurate move:



12.a3!N With the idea of b2-b4, securing White an obvious positional edge.

10.dxc5 ♟xc5 11.b4?!

The quiet 11.0-0 is also worthy of consideration. 11...♟c6 12.♟c3 e5 13.♟a4 ♟e7 14.♟xc6 bxc6 15.♟xe5 ♟c7 16.♟c4 ♟h3 17.♟e1± Though Black has compensation for the pawn I would prefer to be White.

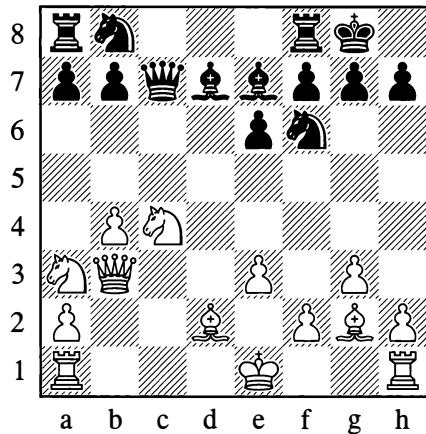
11...♟e7 12.♟b3

After 12.0-0 Black managed to solve his opening problems in the following encounter:

12...a6 13.♟a5 ♟d5 14.a3 b6 15.♟c4 ♟b7= Rausis – Goloshchapov, Germany 2003.

12...♟c7 13.♟ba3 ♟d7

So far we have followed Schwing – Becking, Merzig 1996. White should have continued with:

**14.b5!N**

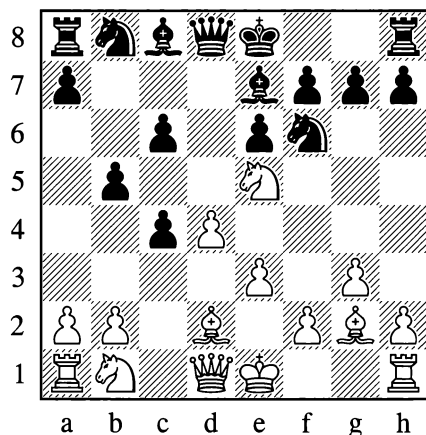
Preventing the simplifying idea of ...♟c6.

14...a6 15.b6 ♟c8 16.♟a5 ♟c6 17.♟3c4

White has very unpleasant pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.

B12) 8...b5

This move has been the most recent trend for Black.



9.a4

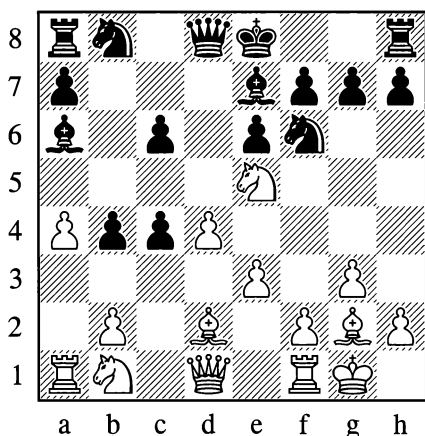
I would be tempted to grab the exchange by 9.♟xc6 ♞xc6 10.♟xc6† ♟d7 11.♟xa8 ♜xa8 12.f3, but I have my concerns about 12...e5!N 13.dxe5 ♞g4 14.0-0 ♞xe5 15.♟c3 ♞d3 with an unclear game.

9...b4 10.0-0

I wasn't satisfied with 10.♞xc4 0-0 11.0-0 ♟a6 12.b3 ♞bd7! which has occurred twice in practice. Black has an adequate game here.

10...♟a6

Here I discovered an interesting idea, connected with an exchange sacrifice:

**11.♜c2N**

I wasn't convinced by 11.♞e1, as in the game Buhmann – Harikrishna, Germany 2011.

11...c3

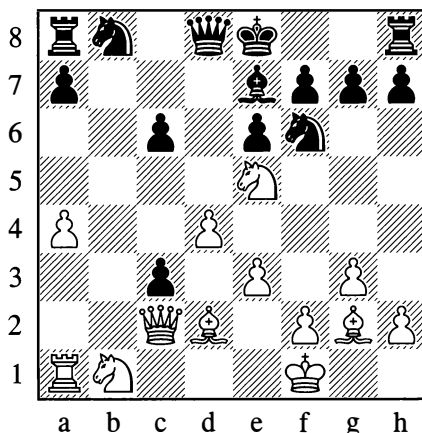
Another line is 11...0-0 12.♞d1, when White will grab the c4-pawn without having to worry about a pin on the f1-a6 diagonal. 12...♜c7 13.♟e1! White intends to grab the c4-pawn, but with his other knight (13.♞xc4 ♞bd7 14.e4 e5 is unclear). The following variation is instructive: 13...♞c8 14.♞d2 ♟b7 15.♜xc4 c5 16.♟xb7 ♜xb7 17.♞b3 ♞bd7 18.♞a5 ♜b6 19.♜b5! With a typical Catalan pull.

12.bxc3 ♟xf1 13.♞xf1

White's Catalan bishop appears to be very efficient and the pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal promises him interesting compensation.

13...bxc3

Another important continuation is 13...♞fd7 14.♞xd7 ♞xd7 15.cxb4 0-0 16.♟xc6 ♞c8 17.♜e4. Play might continue with the following logical sequence of moves: 17...♞f6 18.♜g2 e5 19.d5 e4 20.b5 ♞xd5 21.♜xe4 ♞f6 22.♜d4! White has excellent compensation.

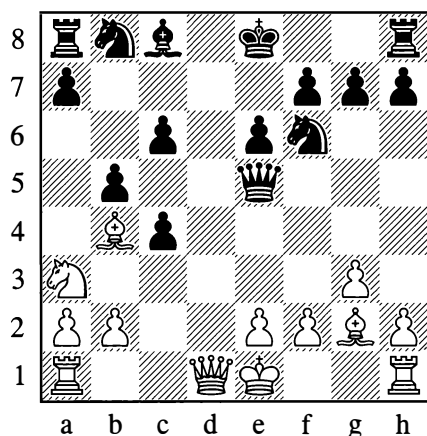


14.♞xc6! ♞xc6 15.♟xc6† ♞d7 16.♟xa8 ♜xa8 17.♜xc3 ♜h1† 18.♞e2 0-0 19.♜c7 ♞d8 20.♟e1 ♜xh2 21.♞c3±

Although material is balanced, White has the more active game.

B2) 7...♜xd4 8.♟xb4 ♜xe5 9.♞a3 b5

Definitely the only move. Black once tried 9...♜c7? and lost quickly after: 10.♞xc4 c5 11.♜d6! ♜xd6 12.♞xd6† ♞d7 13.♟xc5 ♞c6 14.♞d1 ♞c7 15.♞b5† Black resigned before getting mated in one with ♟d6 in Yevseev – Paulsen, Norway 1997.



10.♔d6!

This strong idea was employed by the former European Champion Tkachiev in his game against Ukrainian Grandmaster Goloshchapov in 2003. I believe it poses Black serious problems.

Previously White had tried mainly 10.f4 ♖c7 (10...♗xb2?? loses to 11.♖b1 ♗xa2 12.♗d6 with inevitable mate) 11.♘xb5 cxb5 12.♙xa8 ♙b7 13.♙xb7 ♗xb7, but, as was proven by developments in this line, Black has very good positional compensation for the exchange. 14.0-0 ♗b6† 15.♕h1 ♘c6

Tkachiev's move is the beginning of almost forced play.

10...♗xb2

Black does not have a real alternative to the text:

10...♗f5?! 11.♗d2 Played with the idea of castling long (less convincing is 11.0-0 ♙b7). 11...♙b7 12.♗a5! Another of the ideas of 11.♗d2 – White is threatening ♗c7. 12...♘a6 13.♘b5 ♗d8 (White is winning after 13...♗c8 14.0-0 ♗xb5 15.♗xb5 cxb5 16.♙xb7 ♘d7 17.♗fd1+–) 14.♘c7† ♘d7 15.♙e5 With a huge advantage.

10...♗h5? loses immediately after: 11.♙f3 ♗f5 (11...♗g6 12.♘xb5+–) 12.g4! ♘xg4 13.♙xb8 0-0 (13...♗xb8 14.♗d6 ♗b6 15.♗d1! with a decisive advantage) 14.♙g3 ♘e5 15.♙g2 Despite having three pawns for the piece, Black's position is lost.

11.0-0

Now White is threatening 12.♖b1 followed by 13.♘xb5 with decisive threats.

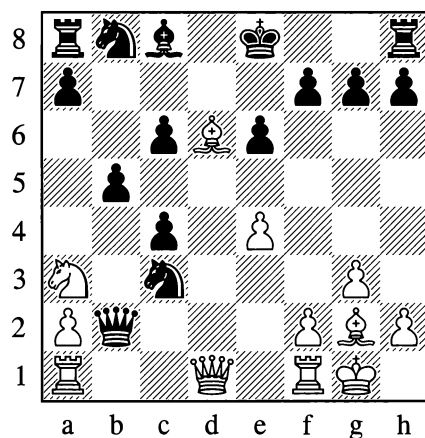
11...♘d5

Black has to block the h1-a8 diagonal.

11...a6?! is not really an option, as can be shown by the following example: 12.♖b1 ♗c3 13.♙xb8 ♗xb8 14.♗d6 ♗b6 15.♘xc4! ♗xc4 16.♖bc1 White was winning in Rodshtein – Novita, Khanty-Mansiysk (ol) 2010.

12.e4 ♘c3

Once again Black doesn't have an alternative, as after 12...♘e7 13.♖b1 ♗c3 (13...♗xa2 loses to 14.♖e1 followed by ♖e2 trapping the queen on a2) 14.e5+– Black cannot prevent both of White's ideas: ♘xb5 and ♙xe7, followed by ♗d6† and ♙xc6.



13.♗h5!

In *GM 1* I only gave **B21**) 13...♘d7, but now we should also consider **B22**) 13...h6!?

B21) 13...♘d7

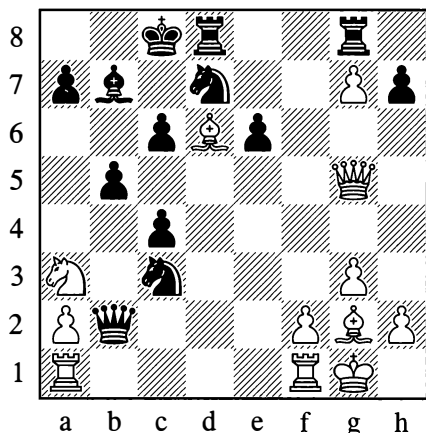
This move has been entirely refuted due to the following line:

14.e5 ♖b7 15.♞g5 f6 16.exf6 0–0–0

Black is ready to sacrifice two pawns to remove his monarch from the danger zone.

Black's position is hardly acceptable after 16...gxf6N 17.♞h5† ♔d8 18.♞ae1 ♞e8 19.♞f7.

17.fxg7 ♞hg8



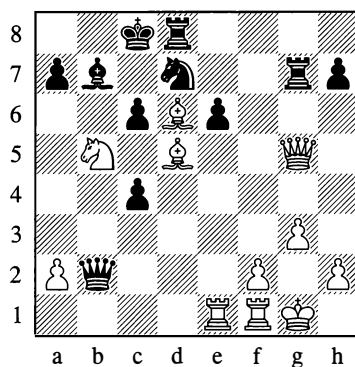
18.♞ae1!

I gave this move as an improvement over existing theory in *GM 1*. Since then it has been used effectively in several correspondence games.

18...♞xg7

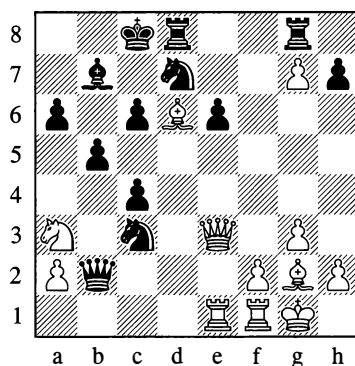
Other options are as follows:

18...♘d5 looks solid for Black, but White crashes through quickly: 19.♙xd5! ♞xg7N (19...exd5 runs into 20.♞e7 ♞f6 21.♞xf6 ♘xf6 22.♞c7† ♖b8 23.♙e5 ♘e8 24.♞f7† ♖a8 25.f4 with a big advantage for White, Kleiser – Murlasits, corr. 2014) Now the brilliant 20.♘xb5!! decides the issue, for example:



20...♞xb5 (20...cxb5 21.♙xb7† ♖xb7 22.♞xd8 leaves Black a rook down) 21.♞xg7 ♞xd5 22.♙e7 c5 23.f3 ♞e8 24.♞f7 ♞h8 25.♞xe6+– With a decisive material advantage.

I considered 18...a6 in *GM 1*. 19.♞e3!!



With this brilliant idea White's queen penetrates to a7 with great effect. 19...♘d5 (19...♞xg7 20.♞a7 ♘d5 21.♘xc4! bxc4 22.♞b1 wins on the spot) 20.♞a7 c3 21.♙xd5 cxd5 22.♞b1 ♞e2 23.♞fc1+– White is winning.

19.♞e3 c5

This is the most stubborn try; other moves are easier for White:

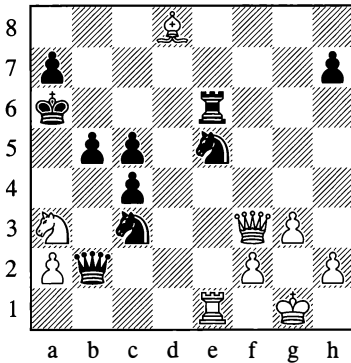
If 19...♘d5 20.♞xa7 ♞f6 21.♞e2 I believe Black is strategically lost, as he is completely tied up on the queenside, while White can gradually improve his position with ♞fe1, ♙h3, or ♘c2–e3. He can also sacrifice with ♘xc4

followed by ♖b1 at any appropriate moment. (Instead 21. ♖xc4 bxc4 22. ♖b1 ♖7b6 23. ♖c5 ♖f4 is still defendable for Black.)

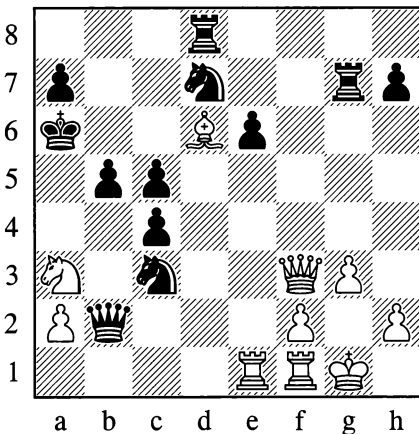
19... ♖b6 20. ♖xe6† ♖gd7 21. ♖h3! c5 22. ♖e7 ♖cd5 23. ♖xd8 ♖xd8 24. ♖e8† ♖c7 25. ♖e5† ♖xe5 26. ♖xe5+– White is winning.

20. ♖xb7† ♖xb7 21. ♖f3† ♖a6!

White's task is easier after 21... ♖b6 22. ♖xe6 ♖g6 (the only move) 23. ♖fe1 ♖e5. Now White has an amazing winning line: 24. ♖e7† ♖xe6 25. ♖xd8† ♖a6



26. ♖a8!! ♖f3† 27. ♖h1! (27. ♖g2 ♖xe1† 28. ♖h1 also wins) 27... ♖xe1† 28. ♖g2 ♖g1† 29. ♖h3 Black cannot avoid mate.

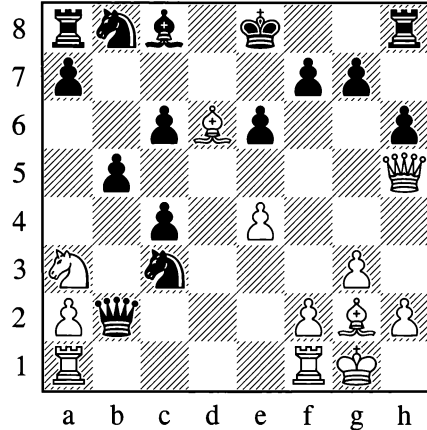


22. ♖e3! ♖d5 23. ♖b1 ♖f6 24. ♖xb5 ♖xf3 25. ♖xf3 c3 26. ♖xc3 ♖xc3 27. ♖xc3 ♖b6

28. ♖xc5

White should convert his extra pawn without too much difficulty.

B22) 13...h6!?



This is Black's latest attempt to rehabilitate the whole variation.

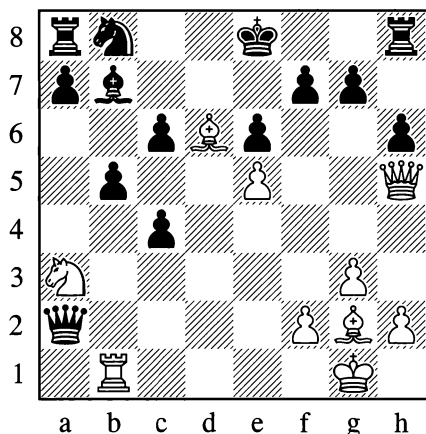
14.e5 ♖b7 15. ♖fb1!

A nice tactical idea which will reveal itself fully in a couple of moves time.

15... ♖xb1

I also checked an obvious alternative: 15... ♖e2 16. ♖f3 (This is even stronger than 16. ♖xe2 ♖xe2† 17. ♖f1 ♖c3 18. ♖xb5! ♖xb1 19. ♖c7† ♖d7 20. ♖xb1 ♖c8 21. ♖xa8 ♖a6 22. ♖b6† axb6 23. ♖xb6± where White is better.) 16... ♖d3 17. ♖xb5 cxb5 18. ♖xb7 ♖xb1 19. ♖g4 ♖d7 20. ♖xa8 ♖c3 21. ♖xg7 ♖h7 22. ♖g4 ♖f5 23. ♖xf5 exf5 24. ♖b4! ♖e4 25. ♖c6 White is close to winning.

16. ♖xb1 ♖xa2



17. Rxb5!

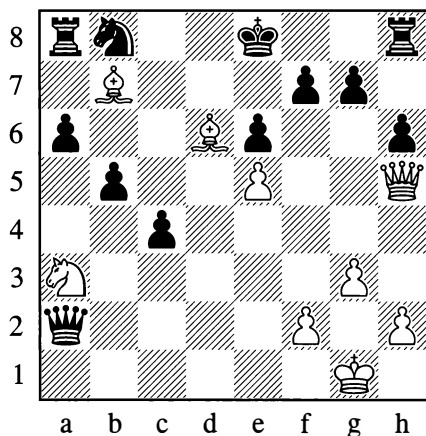
The point of White's previous exchange sacrifice.

17...cxb5 18. Bxb7

White looks to be winning in both of the following lines:

18...a6

18...c3 19. Wh4 g5 20. We4+-



19. Bxa8 Wa1+ 20. Qg2 Bd4 21. Nc2N

21. Wf3 has also scored heavily in correspondence games.

21...Wb6 22. Wg4! g6 23. Nd4

With a decisive advantage.

Conclusion

As in *GM 1*, I believe that White is doing well in all variations in this chapter. Following the sequence 6. dxe5 b5 7. dxc6 Wb6 8. da5 d5 9. Bd2, I have updated and improved my analysis of 9...a6 – with the Catalan bishop often playing a starring role.

After 6. dxe5 Bb4+ 7. Bd2! Wxd4 8. Bxb4 Wxe5 9. da3 b5, Tkachiev's 10. Bd6! remains the strongest move. Following the further sequence 10...Wxb2 11. 0-0 d5 12. e4 dc3 13. Wh5! I now also considered 13...h6!?, which was Black's most recent try in the realm of correspondence chess. However, White has a powerful exchange sacrifice at his disposal on move 15 which would appear to lead to a decisive advantage in all cases.